Steven Boada, Ph.D

Basic Information

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Professional Experience

Activision Publishing, Inc. — Boulder, Colorado

Lead Data Scientist, Gameplay — **March, 2026 - Present**

As part of the game science team, I lead data scientists working to make Call of Duty better for our players. I combine a deep ML engineering background with hands-on people leadership, experimentation strategy, and cross-functional partnerships. Specifically, I:

- Define and lead high-impact analytics initiatives with design leadership, analyzing how gameplay systems (maps, modes, weapons, communication systems, etc.) influence player behavior and top-line KPIs, and translating insights into actionable design recommendations.
- Own experimentation strategy for gameplay features, guiding the design and evaluation of A/B tests, statistical models, and large-scale player behavior analyses.
- Champion gameplay measurement strategy and data quality, partnering with engineering to improve telemetry coverage, instrumentation, and analytical reliability.
- Elevate team analytical capability by mentoring data scientists, reviewing experimental designs and analyses, and promoting best practices in experimentation, statistics, and data storytelling.

Senior Data Scientist, Gameplay — **January, 2024 - 2026**

- Restarted advanced gameplay analytics support for partner studios and live Call of Duty titles.
- Highlighted Project: Led study design and analysis of input advantage across controller and mouse/keyboard players, directly resulting in a rework of the aim assist system shipped in Black Ops 7 (2025).

Senior Machine Learning Engineer — **January, 2021 - 2024**

- Provided technical direction and leadership to junior data scientists end-to-end — designing, developing, and deploying recommendation systems integrated into Modern Warfare 2 (2022) and Modern Warfare 3 (2023).
- Designed and maintained ML infrastructure including autoML, CI/CD pipelines (Jenkins, GitHub Actions), model tracking (MLflow), and orchestration (Airflow).
- Developed near-realtime applications (via Spark streaming) to identify and mitigate in-game cheating and malicious behaviors, achieving action times in the low 10s of seconds.
- Spearheaded the transition of ML infrastructure from AWS to GCP/GCS, optimizing scalability and performance.
- Built customer conversion, churn prediction, and behavioral segmentation models using survival analysis, clustering, and tree-based methods.

Insight Data Science — New York, New York

Fellow — **January, 2020 - 2021**

- Completed a data science bootcamp focused on transitioning academics into the tech industry, working on real-world data problems.
- Built a random forest model in Python to prioritize NYC restaurant inspections, improving violation detection by 2.5% and identifying critical issues up to 7 days earlier through an AWS-deployed API.

Skills

Machine Learning: Linear Models, Decision Trees, SVM, Clustering, Deep Learning, Survival Analysis
Engineering & MLOps: Open Source Contributor, Python, Spark, SQL, MLflow, Airflow, Docker, Jenkins, GitHub Actions, AWS, GCP, Databricks
Leadership: Team management, mentorship, experimental design review, cross-functional stakeholder communication, workshop facilitation, Eagle Scout
AI & Agentic Systems: LLM integration (Claude, GPT), prompt engineering, agentic workflow design, multi-agent orchestration, AI coding tools (Claude Code, GitHub Copilot, etc.)

Education

Texas A&M University, College Station, Texas

- Ph.D, Physics (astronomy focus), 2016

The University of Tennessee, Knoxville, Tennessee

- M.S., Physics (astronomy focus), 2009
- B.S., Physics, 2007